

SECOND SESSION – TENTH PARLIAMENT

FIRST REPORT

OF THE PORTFOLIO COMMITTEE ON LANDS, AGRICULTURE, WATER, FISHERIES AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT

ON

THE STATE OF FOOD SECURITY IN THE COUNTRY

(S.C.06, 2024)

ORDERED IN TERMS OF STANDING ORDER No. 18:

(1) At the commencement of every session, there must be as many committees to be designated according to government portfolios as the Standing Rules and Orders Committee may deem fit.

(2) Each select committee must be known by the portfolio determined for it by the Standing Rules and Orders Committee.

TERMS OF REFERENCE OF PORTFOLIO COMMITTEES S.O 21

Subject to these Standing Orders, a Portfolio Committee must-

(a) examine expenditure administration and policy of government departments and other matters falling under their jurisdictions as Parliament may, by resolution determine;

(b) consider and deal with all Bills and Statutory Instruments or other matters which are referred to it by or under a resolution of the House or by the Speaker;

(c) consider or deal with an appropriation or money Bill or any aspect of an appropriation or money Bill referred to it by these Standing Orders or by or under resolution of this House;

(d) monitor, investigate, enquire into and make recommendations relating to any aspect of the legislative programme, budget, policy or any other matter it may consider relevant to the government department falling within the category of affairs assigned to it, and may for that purpose consult and liaise with such department; and

(e) consider or deal with all international treaties, conventions and agreements relevant to it, which are from time to time negotiated, entered into or agreed upon.

On Thursday, 12 October 2023, the Hon. Speaker of Parliament announced that the Standing Rules and Orders Committee had nominated the following Members to serve the Portfolio Committee on Lands, Agriculture Water, Fisheries and Rural Resettlement:

1. Hon. Bonda J.
2. Hon. Chinodakufa I
3. Hon. Jimu L
4. Hon. Karumazondo T
5. Hon. Kuka J

6. Hon. Masvisvi D
7. Hon. Matangira R
8. Hon. Moyo V
9. Hon. Mundungehama S
10. Hon. Murambiwa O
11. Hon. Ngwenya S 12. Hon. Nyabani T
13. Hon. Njanji M.
14. Hon. Sagandira
15. Hon. Sakupwanya S
16. Hon. Sihlabo V
17. Hon. Sithole J
18. Hon. Sithole S
19. Hon. Tasikani I
20. Hon. Ncube F
21. Hon. Rungwave
22. Hon. Batitsa N
23. Hon. Hakata G
24. Hon. Jimu L
25. Hon Maseko S
26. Hon. Masuku E 27. Hon. Matinyanya M.S.
28. Hon. Mhuri W
29. Hon. Sithole G.K
30. Hon. Taedzwa J
31. Hon. Zevezayi C
32. Hon. Zvaipa I
33. Hon. Zhou Tafanana

Hon. Saul Maburutse to be the Chairperson.

INRODUCTION

Following the El Niño-induced drought, which devastated Southern Africa countries in early 2024, the Parliamentary Portfolio Committee on Lands, Agriculture, Water, Fisheries and Rural Development resolved to conduct an inquiry into the food security situation in Zimbabwe. The inquiry aimed at providing a thorough assessment of Zimbabwe's food security challenges and contribute in guide the development of a comprehensive, multi-faceted strategy to overcome the challenges.

1.0 Background

1.1 Zimbabwe has for some years grappled with food security issues, stemming from a complex interplay of historical, economic, and environmental factors. The country's agricultural sector has been shaped by the legacy of colonial land redistribution, which concentrated productive farmland in the hands of a small white minority. At independence in 1980, approximately 6,000 large-scale commercial farmers, who were predominantly white, owned 15.5 million hectares of land, while 700,000 smallholder farmers occupied the remaining 16.4 million hectares (Moyo, 2011). This unequal land tenure system was partially addressed through the Fast-Track Land Reform Programme in the early 2000s, but issues of productivity, financing, and infrastructure development continued to hinder the recovery of the agricultural sector. A recent study revealed that while the land reform programme increased the number of farming households, the average farm size decreased substantially, leading to decline in crop yields and agricultural productivity (Scoones et al., 2019).

1.2 In addition to land tenure challenges, the privatization of agricultural financing and the limited availability of credit for small-scale farmers have further constrained the sector's growth. According to the Agricultural show report, (2011), only 20% of small-scale farmers in Zimbabwe had access to formal credit, with the majority relying on informal sources or personal savings to finance their agricultural activities (Moyo, 2011). This lack of access to credit has hindered farmers' ability to invest in acquisition of inputs, such as seeds, fertilizers and equipment, necessary to maintain and improve their yields, contributing to the country's ongoing food insecurity. The situation was further exacerbated by the devastating impact of El Niño-induced drought in early 2024, which struck the region with unprecedented intensity. According to the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) (2024), the El Niño-induced drought caused an estimated $3.2 billion in agricultural losses across Southern Africa, severely

impacting food production and leaving millions of people in need of humanitarian assistance (FAO, 2024).

2.0 Objectives

The Portfolio Committee conducted an inquiry to achieve the following objectives:

1. Assess the impact of El Niño-induced drought on agricultural production and food security; 2. Examine the underlying structural issues impacting on the agricultural sector and performance;

3. Evaluate the government's immediate response and interventions to address food security.

3.0 METHODOLOGY

In undertaking this enquiry, the Committee adopted traditionally used methodologies by Parliament that foster the highest levels of transparency and therefore contribute to the report's overall credibility and reliability.

3.1 Oral Evidence Sessions

The Committee held oral evidence sessions with the following key stakeholders: -

- Grain Marketing Board (G.M.B);
- Silo Foods Industry;
- Grain Millers Association of Zimbabwe (GMAZ); and
- Ministry of Lands, Agriculture, Water, Fisheries and Rural Development.

3.2 Fact Finding Visits

The Committee visited selected Grain Marketing Boards Depots which are;

- Aspindale;
- Norton;
- Chegutu;
- Lion's Den;
- Banket; and
- Chinhoyi;

4.0 FINDINGS

The Committee's inquiry into the impact of the El Niño-induced drought on agricultural production and food security in Zimbabwe revealed a complex situation. The findings

highlighted the devastating effects of the drought on crop yields and livestock, as well as the structural issues that have long plagued the agricultural sector. Additionally, the Committee's assessment of the government's response and interventions uncovered both strengths and limitations in addressing the challenges.

4.1 The impact of El Niño-induced drought on agricultural production and food security

The Committee observed that the El Nino induced drought had a devastating effect on agricultural production in Zimbabwe. The statistics presented highlighted the severity of the situation, with Silo Food Industries, a major food processing company, receiving only 1,934 metric tonnes of maize from the Grain Marketing Board (GMB) in December 2023, 3,460 metric tonnes in January 2024, and 1,267 metric tonnes in February 2024, against a target of 8,000 metric tonnes per month. This resulted in a significant shortfall of 3,339 metric tonnes (42% of the target) that underscored the urgent need for action to address the food shortages and prevent the situation from worsening. The agricultural industry, a critical component of Zimbabwe's economy, suffered significant losses, resulting in higher food costs and lower household incomes.

4.1.1 The Committee observed that the agricultural sector in Zimbabwe was over-reliant on rain-fed agriculture, making it highly vulnerable to climate-related shocks such as droughts and floods. This over-reliance had severe consequences, including reduced crop yields, decreased food security and increased poverty. The Committee noted that the recent drought-induced El Nino phenomenon had further exacerbated the sector's vulnerability, necessitating the need for urgent action to address this issue. The Committee was concerned that the lack of investment in irrigation infrastructure and water harvesting techniques had worsened the impact of the drought, leaving many farmers without alternative sources of water for their crops.

4.2 The structural issues impacting the agricultural sector

4.2.1 The Committee's investigation revealed numerous challenges, including issues with land tenure security and the dispersed nature of smallholder farms, which hindered agricultural production and investment, contributing to a 71% shortfall in maize supply compared to the target. Farmers also struggled to access essential inputs, financial services, quality seeds, fertilizers, and modern equipment. The Committee also observed that farmers did not prefer to sell their products to the GMB because of the considerable delays up to months before receiving

payments after delivery. The delays put a financial strain on farmers and drove them to look for other buyers who could pay them on delivery. In addition, the process of selling to the GMB had grown unduly complex, with problems such as of bureaucracy, ambiguous guidelines, and logistical difficulties. The statistics highlighted the severity with Silo Food Industries receiving only a fraction of its 8,000 MT monthly target from the GMB, underscoring the devastating impact on Zimbabwe's agricultural industry and the urgent need for interventions to address the food security situation.

4.3.3 The government's immediate response and interventions

The Committee found that the government's approach to food security in Zimbabwe considered various stocks including those held by the Grain Marketing Board (GMB), households and private millers with a push for private sector transparency in stock declarations. The government's multi-faceted strategy included increasing wheat production, targeting 1.8 million metric tons of maize annually for the strategic grain reserve and mobilizing resources for borehole drilling and irrigation to combat potential water shortages caused by the El Niño. The liberalization policy has mandated private sector engagement in agricultural contracts, with companies required to register with the Agricultural Marketing Authority (AMA) and meet minimum input support requirements, which has reduced GMB's intake as farmers now sell directly to millers but has also increased competition and encouraged higher agricultural production. The Committee also found that the government gave GMAZ the mandate to provide GMOs to the commercial market, and the role of the GMB has been limited to strategic grain reserve management, with the private sector now allowed to engage in contract farming.

5.0 OBSEVATIONS

5.1 Market Liberalization

The Committee welcomed the liberation of the market to Agriculture products. However, the Committee noted that despite the potential advantages of market liberalization, the government has been overly reliant on the private sector for maize supply. This has led to a decline in the overall maize supply available for distribution through the GMB. The Committee observed that the private sector is not selling their maize to the GMB and this has resulted in a shortage of maize at the GMB. This over-reliance on the private sector for maize supply has been a significant concern during the El Niño-induced drought, as the government will struggle to maintain adequate food security levels.

5.2 Government Support for the Grain Marketing Board (GMB)

The Committee observed that the government has taken steps to support the operations of the Grain Marketing Board (GMB) in addressing the country's food security challenges. These efforts included providing financial resources to the GMB to enable it to purchase and distribute maize to the citizens. The government has also implemented policies to encourage farmers to sell their maize output to the GMB, such as setting minimum prices and offering incentives. Additionally, the government invested in the GMB's storage and logistical infrastructure to improve its capacity to handle and distribute the maize.

5.3The Committee's Observations on GMAZ's Role

The Committee observed that the government had given the Grain Millers Association of Zimbabwe (GMAZ) the mandate to provide maize to the commercial market, reflecting the government's recognition of GMAZ's role in addressing the country's food security challenges. The Committee noted that this shift in responsibilities, where the government has limited the role of the Grain Marketing Board (GMB) to strategic grain reserve management while empowering GMAZ to take a more active role in the commercial maize supply, aims to leverage the private sector to complement the efforts of the GMB. However, the Committee raised concerns about GMAZ's importation of genetically modified organisms (GMOs) intended for human consumption, emphasizing the importance of proper labeling, traceability and segregation of GMO products to ensure food safety and consumer awareness. Additionally, the Committee identified weaknesses in GMAZ's approach, observing that the increased role of GMAZ in the commercial maize supply chain had led to a decline in the overall maize available for distribution through the GMB, raising concerns about the long-term sustainability and equitable access to maize for the citizens.

5.4 Limitations in the Government's Response

While the Committee welcomed the liberalization of the market, they noted that the government should have had a more precise understanding of the maize stocks held by the private sector. This information could have helped the government to better coordinate and respond to the food security challenge. The Committee observed that the lack of detailed information on private sector maize stocks hindered the government's ability to effectively manage the food security situation.

6.0 RECOMMENDATIONS

The committee recommends the following;

6.1 Develop comprehensive recommendations to strengthen food security

The Committee recommends that the Zimbabwean Government develops a comprehensive plan to strengthen the country's food security by the end of 2024.

6.2 Provide a roadmap for long-term agricultural transformation

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Lands, Agriculture, Water, Fisheries and Rural Development should create a long-term strategy for the transformation of the agricultural sector in Zimbabwe by 2028. This should address the structural issues identified such as land tenure security and the challenges faced by smallholder farmers and lay the groundwork for sustainable and resilient agricultural development.

6.3 Improve the operations and efficiency of the Grain Marketing Board (GMB) The Committee recommends that by the end of the 2024 -2025 season the government should have reviewed and streamlined the operations of the GMB, addressing the issues of delayed farmer payments and the complex bureaucratic processes that have discouraged farmers from selling to the GMB. This could involve enhancing transparency, improving logistics and ensuring timely payments to farmers.

6.4 Strengthen regulation and oversight of GMO imports

The Committee suggests that Government should implement robust regulations and oversight mechanisms to ensure the proper labeling, traceability, and segregation of GMO products intended for human consumption by end of 2025. This would help safeguard the health and safety of the Zimbabwean population.

6.5 Investing in Irrigation

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Lands, Agriculture, Water, Fisheries and Rural Development should develop a comprehensive irrigation development plan by June 2025,

6.6 Allocation of sufficient funds

The government should allocate sufficient funds for irrigation infrastructure development in the 2025-2026 budget. Additionally, the Zimbabwe National Water Authority should prioritize water harvesting techniques and develop a water harvesting strategy by September 2024.

6.7 Promotion of conservative agriculture practices

The Agricultural Marketing Authority should promote conservation agriculture practices among farmers by December 2024.

6.7 Provision of technical assistance

The Ministry of Environment, Climate, Tourism and Hospitality Industry should provide technical assistance to farmers on agroforestry practices by March 2025.

7.0 CONCLUSION

The Committee's inquiry highlighted the multiple challenges facing Zimbabwe's agricultural sector in the wake of the recent El Niño-induced drought. From the devastating impact on crop production to the systemic issues of land tenure, access to inputs, and climate vulnerability, the Committee identified a range of interventions required to address the current food insecurity crisis. Only through a holistic and coordinated response can Zimbabwe build a more resilient and productive agricultural system capable of ensuring food security for its citizens. The Committee stands ready to work closely with the government to implement these critical recommendations and overcome the current challenges facing the sector.